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The Inheritance of Post-Maoism: An examination of Zhang Xiaogang, Song Dong, and He Chengyao across mediums

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Contemporary Chinese art remains eternally haunted by the unresolved remnants of political terror. The post-impact period, after the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), has left an inheritance for subsequent generations of psychological and societal trauma, long after its conclusion. The psychic rupture of the Chinese people as a whole after the Cultural Revolution has endured, continually shaping the memories, emotions, and existence of Chinese subjects in post-socialist modernity.[1] While state narratives present Maoism as a closed chapter in China's development, Chinese artists unveil a more somber reality, revealing that political violence does not vanish with regime shifts. Rather, its impactful permeation has permanently ingrained itself within family structures, domestic settings, and individual bodies. Zhang Xiaogang's family portraits,[2] Song Dong's autobiographical video installation,[3] and He Chengyao's evocative performance art,[4] vividly depict these dynamics.

The afterlife of Maoism is not treated as a singular ideology. Its immortality emerges through inherited trauma, which is perpetually relived and fragmented. These artists dispel mimetic historical representations in favor of visual testimonies, laying bare trauma as the core condition of post-Mao subjectivity. Trauma functions as a force, molding awareness long after political systems have faded. The ways in which various contemporary Chinese artists represent familial trauma depend critically on which medium they use. Zhang Xiaogang's paintings create distance through their repetitive imagery. Song Dong's autobiographical work achieves intimacy through physical engagement with family objects. Additionally, He Chengyao's performance embodies trauma directly through her body. Each medium doesn't just convey trauma; it fundamentally shapes how that trauma can be experienced and understood. Each medium fosters

[1] MacFarquhar, Roderick. *The Origins of the Cultural Revolution, 2: The Great Leap Forward, 1958-1960*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1983.
[2] Figure 1. Zhang Xiaogang. *Bloodline: Big Family* series. 1993–1999. Oil on canvas. Various dimensions.
[3] Figure 2. Song Dong. *Touching My Father*. 1997–2011. Video installation.
[4] Figure 3. He Chengyao. *Opening the Great Wall*. 2001. Performance art, photographic documentation.

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distinct emotional engagements with the Maoist past, from emotional detachment to physical exposure, highlighting its role in transmitting family histories across generations. Synthesizing scholarship in cultural memory and affect, the following analysis elucidates how these various artistic mediums uniquely structure modes of inheritance, demonstrating how these artists' practices illuminate the persistent influence of familial trauma in contemporary art.

Familial relationships occupy a central yet unstable position in contemporary Chinese engagements with the Maoist past. During Mao Zedong's leadership, spanning from 1949 to 1976, domestic policies and campaigns, such as the Great Leap Forward (1958–1962)[5] and the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976),[6] significantly altered family structures and personal lives.[7] While official narratives emphasize collective history and ideological transformation, artists have turned toward the family as the site where political violence was lived, internalized, and transmitted across generations. Within this intimate sphere, the history documented in scholarship and collective discussions remains far from empty. History's effects persist through inherited conditions shaped by silence, emotional restraint, and unresolved loss, with psychological effects that continue in the present day.

The familial experiences of political campaigns, famine, denunciation, and displacement were absorbed within domestic spaces, shaping parenting, emotional expression, and bodily comportment in the post-Mao context. These experiences emerge through affective atmospheres, habitual behaviors, and embodied vulnerabilities, in contrast to conventional historical

[5] The Great Leap Forward occurred from 1958 to 1962. For comprehensive analysis, see Frank Dikötter, *Mao's Great Famine: The History of China's Most Devastating Catastrophe, 1958-1962* (New York: Walker & Company, 2010).
[6] The Cultural Revolution lasted from 1966 to 1976. See Roderick MacFarquhar, *The Origins of the Cultural Revolution, 2: The Great Leap Forward, 1958-1960* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1983).
[7] Frank Dikötter, *Mao's Great Famine: The History of China's Most Devastating Catastrophe, 1958-1962* (New York: Walker & Company, 2010); Roderick MacFarquhar, *The Origins of the Cultural Revolution, 2: The Great Leap Forward, 1958-1960* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1983).

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representations. This concept of affective atmospheres can be anchored in Brian Massumi's theory of intensity, the pre-conscious, bodily dimension of experience that exceeds linguistic capture. Massumi describes intensity as something we feel in our bodies before we can think about it consciously.[8] Chinese families after the Maoist period displayed an apparent intensity through forms of unspoken tensions and emotional restraint. Children grew up absorbing these atmospheres without understanding their political origins. Artists engaging with family history must confront how different artistic mediums shape the visibility and legibility of inherited trauma. Familial trauma thus emerges as a relational process shaped by artistic form, opposite to a unified psychological condition.

The paradox structuring contemporary Chinese cultural memory is that the Cultural Revolution is simultaneously everywhere and nowhere, hypervisible yet systematically occluded. Officially declared finished within state historiography, its psychological consequences proliferate across intimate spaces and private life, destabilizing family bonds and artistic practice. In the decades following Mao's death, Chinese artists have mounted a sustained epistemic refusal of monumental history, turning instead to the domestic, the bodily, and the archival, spaces where trauma inscribes itself beyond state control. This is not depoliticization. Rather, it represents radical ontological excavation, recognizing that Maoism's most devastating effects operate through psychic interiority, where violence becomes embodied, generationally heritable, and structurally reproduced across temporal divides. Chinese artists are not alone in turning to intimacy to represent trauma. German artist Anselm Kiefer uses heavily layered paintings to explore Nazi history.[9] South African artist William Kentridge creates animated films

[8] Brian Massumi. *Parables for the Virtual: Movement, Affect, Sensation*. (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2002). Augmented twentieth anniversary edition, 2021, 27.
[9] Figure 4. Anselm Kiefer. *Innenraum (Interior)*, 1981, via Royal Academy of Arts, London. Source: TheCollector. https://www.thecollector.com/anselm-kiefer-third-reich-architecture-approach/.

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about apartheid memory.[10] Like Chinese artists, both Kiefer and Kentridge use intimate, fragmented approaches rather than following official historical narratives. Yet the Chinese case presents distinct challenges. Where German and South African artists work within established frameworks of transitional justice and public reckoning, Chinese artists navigate a context in which official acknowledgment remains foreclosed. This absence of remembrance returns to the core family as the primary site of memory work.

Xiaogang's *Bloodline* paintings intentionally use motifs similar to family photograph albums, examining how inherited trauma is mediated through distance and repetition. The paintings depict, in muted tones of gray and yellow, rigidly posed figures with faces almost mask-like and lacking distinguishing features. Each figure's eyes are slightly averted or stare directly ahead, giving them a detached and solemn appearance, and faint red lines connect the figures. These lines are barely visible, painted with diluted pigment. In *Bloodline No. 2* (1993),[11] the lines connect specific body parts, such as the father's temple, the mother's wrist, and the child's heart. This creates a biological visual system, such as blood vessels, further suggesting how ideology shapes family connections. The lines are so faint they almost disappear, causing viewers to lean in closely, enacting the very search for intimacy the painting denies. The figures' expressions are frozen and uniform, with minimal details to distinguish them from one another, such as subtle blush marks or a lock of hair. Rather than simply depicting collective trauma, *Bloodline* reveals the inherent limitations of pictorial representation in confronting inherited familial suffering. Looking across the faces, it becomes hard to distinguish any recognizable

[10] Figure 5. William Kentridge (South African b. 1955), Johannesburg, 2nd Greatest City after Paris, from Drawings for Projection, 1989–91, 16mm animated film transferred to optical disk, 8 minutes, 2 seconds, dimensions variable. The Jewish Museum, New York. Purchase: Mr. and Mrs. George Jaffin Fund, Fine Arts Acquisition Committee Fund, and Lillian Gordon Bequest, 2001-12. Source: TheJewishMuseum. https://thejewishmuseum.org/exhibitions/south-african-projections-films-by-william-kentridge/.

[11] Figure 6. Zhang Xiaogang (b. 1993). *Bloodline – Big Family: Family No. 2* (1995). Signed in Chinese and Pinyin and dated 1993, framed. Oil on canvas. 110 x 130 cm. 43 ¼ x 51 ⅛ cm.

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emotion. Their deliberately flattened expressions resist interpretation, making only minor details to separate the figures. This visual strategy mirrors the ideological conformity that shaped everyday life under Maoism,[12] as Xiaogang's restrained handling of paint drains the figures of expressive individuality. Instead of conveying trauma through explicit violence, there is a systematic absence of emotional depth, emphasizing the pervasive emotional detachment of the era and raising crucial ethical questions about the aestheticization of trauma. Xiaogang's refined aesthetic, although already being extensively examined, raises an ethical question. Is he making trauma too beautiful and too marketable for international collectors? It can be argued that the *Bloodline* series succeeds commercially because it makes trauma palatable. However, this criticism overlooks an important point of Xiaogang's repetitive style. It enacts the ideological flattening it depicts, in that the painting doesn't resolve this tension; instead, it stages it, forcing viewers to confront their own consumption of suffering as an aesthetic object.

In the Maoist era, family photographs served as a performance of ideological conformity shaped by political discipline. Analyzing Zhang Xiaogang's canvases, his paintings reproduce rather than resolve the mediated distance inherent in historical photographs. Consequently, viewers encounter familial trauma as prefiltered and aesthetically distanced, from loss and emotional breakdown that's presented in maintaining separation between representation and lived experience. Familial suffering becomes legible and even iconic; even so, it remains confined within the boundaries of representation. The paintings prevent negotiation or confrontation, presenting trauma as already organized and historical.

[12] Felix Wemheuer, *A Social History of Maoist China: Conflict and Change, 1949–1976* (Oakland: University of California Press, 2019); MacFarquhar, *Origins of the Cultural Revolution;* Dikötter, *Mao's Great Famine.*

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Song Dong's *Touching My Father* (1997 - 2011)[13] offers a radically different mode of engagement. The combination of autobiographical writing, archival reflection, and installation stages an intimate encounter between son and father that resists both aesthetic detachment and historical abstraction. Dong approaches family history as a relational and ethical process, unfolding through touch, memory, and the act of writing itself. Dong's video installation,[14] emerged from his attempt to bridge the emotional distance with his father during his father's lifetime, though the work continued to evolve after his father's death in 2002. Dong's duality in working with performance, video, and installation, where he is both creator of visual culture and a son negotiating emotional distance, obligation, and inherited history, is central to the work's significance. Dong frames the difficulty of approaching the parent as both a historical subject shaped by Maoist campaigns and an intimate presence marked by emotional distance.

The act of "touching" is crucial here, both literally and metaphorically, as *Touching My Father* (1997–2011) is a three-part creation. The work's first iteration involved a video of Dong's own hand on his father's living body, slowly sweeping across his father's face and body before stopping at his heart. Unlike visual representation, which presupposes a distance between the viewer and the object, this projected touch attempts proximity while acknowledging its impossibility. The work's second part is a videotape of touching his father's body after death; this tape remains sealed. In the final part, Dong projected his father's image onto water. When he tried to touch the water, the image disappeared. This installation uncovers the ethical and emotional challenges of filial connection in Chinese culture, where physical contact between fathers and sons is traditionally discouraged. Dong's interactions with his father's body, belongings, and memory break apart the separation between artistic practice and filial

[13] Figure 2. Song Dong. *Touching My Father*. (1997–2011). Video installation.
[14] Figure 2. Song Dong. *Touching My Father*. (1997–2011). Video installation.

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responsibility. The work suggests that familial trauma cannot be accessed solely through interpretation or representation; it requires a form of embodied encounter that acknowledges both longing and impossibility.

Dong's textual reflectionism, instead of reconstructing an account of the father's life, registers hesitation, uncertainty, and emotional restraint. These qualities reflect a larger narrative of familial communication under Maoist socialism's censorship that structured domestic relationships.[15] Silence, in this context, is an absence of speech, and has further developed as an inherited mode of interaction.[16] Dong's work does not overcome this silence; it circles around it, acknowledging both its persistence and its emotional cost. Furthermore, treating silence itself as an artistic material emphasizes its formative role in shaping familial narratives, much like objects and texts. This artistically intentional framing of muteness enriches the thesis that each medium contributes uniquely to the practice of inheritance, positioning silence as a potent conveyor of unspoken histories and emotional legacies. Dong's video installation is a paradox; "touching" is an intimate word, and he reinforces this through a multilayered use of this motif. Dong's symbolic title of touching and the false act of trying to physically touch the reflection of his father are both contradictory. In addition, he uses technology as a medium, further playing with the antithesis of intimacy.

This approach distinguishes *Touching My Father* (1997–2011) from more familiar modes of trauma representation. Rather than externalizing suffering through visual markers or a narrative climax, Dong foregrounds the ethical tension of speaking for another, particularly a parent whose experiences exceed the son's. The work thus resonates with broader debates in

[15] Felix Wemheuer, *A Social History of Maoist China: Conflict and Change, 1949–1976* (Oakland: University of California Press, 2019).
[16] Wu Hung, *Contemporary Chinese Art: A History* (London: Thames & Hudson, 2014), 156.

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memory studies concerning the limits of testimony and the responsibility of second-generation witnesses.[17] While concepts such as postmemory can help articulate this dynamic, Dong's project complicates them by emphasizing not inheritance alone, but negotiation.[18] Memory here isn't passively received; it is actively, and often painfully, worked through within a familial relationship. Importantly, *Touching My Father* (1997–2011) refuses closure. There is no resolution of filial distance, no reconciliation between past and present. Instead, the work remains suspended in an ongoing process of engagement. This refusal reflects an ethical stance, claiming understanding or mastery of the father's experience would risk appropriating it. Dong's restraint stands in contrast to more spectacular or confrontational artistic strategies, underscoring the limits of exposure as a response to trauma.

The spatial and material elements of *Touching My Father* (1997–2011) further reinforce this intimacy. Personal objects, documents, and traces of everyday life function as points of contact rather than as illustrative evidence. Their significance lies less in what they reveal historically than in how they mediate affective connection. These materials resist monumentalization, remaining stubbornly ordinary. The work emphasizes how historical change in China is often registered through lived, sensory engagement rather than grand narrative.[19] Dong's project situates memory within the textures of daily life, where political history is absorbed indirectly through familial routines and emotional habits. Dong similarly explores materiality through his installation, *Waste Not* (物盡其用, Wu Jin Qi Yong, 2005),[20] which

[17] Rahul K. Gairola and Sharanya Jayawickrama, *Memory, Trauma, Asia: Recall, Affect, and Orientalism in Contemporary Narratives* (London: Routledge, 2021), 72.Gairola and Jayawickrama 2021
[18] Wu Hung, *Contemporary Chinese Art: A History, 1970s–2000s* (London: Thames & Hudson, 2014), 1999, 123, 287–289.
[19] "Making Urban Memory Visible: The On-Screen Transformation of Beijing's Hutong Districts during Modernization (1940s–2010s)," *Urban History* (2025): 1–20, https://doi.org/10.1017/S0963926824000190."Making urban memory visible: the on-screen transformation of Beijing's hutong districts during modernization (1940s–2010s)" 2025.
[20] Figure 7. Song Dong. *Waste Not*. (物盡其用, Wu Jin Qi Yong*).* Art Installation.

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displays over 10,000 objects his mother hoarded throughout her life. The work emerged after his father's death in 2002, when his mother's compulsive saving intensified as a response to grief. Rather than framing this as mental illness, the work reveals how his mother's practice of extreme thrift reflected survival strategies developed during the scarcity of the 1960s and 1970s. The title comes from his mother's phrase "wu jin qi yong" (waste not), which encapsulates her philosophy, shaped by decades of material deprivation under Maoism.[21] The installation transforms private accumulation into a public archive, where his mother's possessions become evidence of how political history inscribes itself through domestic habits and material relations.

He Chengyao emerges as a pivotal artist who employs performance art to interrogate inherited family trauma. The gendered involvement in her works is powerful, as she questions the embodied care expected of daughters. This approach transforms from filial to maternal dynamics, emphasizing how her performative practices directly confront familial trauma through bodily exposure. In this way, she stages inheritance as an embodied, gendered, and public condition inseparable from structures of care and vulnerability. Rather than using performance alone to represent memory or narrative, Chengyao reconfigures the maternal relationship as a site of embodied reckoning, positioning the female body as the locus where familial trauma is neither depicted nor mediated; it is actively enacted. The analysis foregrounds the specificity of Chengyao's engagement with familial trauma.

He Chengyao's artistic practice is fundamentally shaped by her family history. Chengyao's mother suffered from mental illness. Her father was imprisoned due to his political views during the Maoist period, leaving her mother to care for three children, after which her

[21] Song Dong, Hong Kong Baptist University (BKU): Honorary Doctorates and Honorary University Fellows, https://www.hkbu.edu.hk/en/about/honorary-doctorates-and-honorary-university-fellows/song-dong.html.

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mother's mental health deteriorated.[22] Chengyao treats this history as a lived inheritance that structures her subjectivity. In *Opening the Great Wall* (2001),[23] Chengyao appeared nude in a public space, exposing her body as a form of provocation, creating agency that embodies testimony within collective vulnerability.[24] Her nudity materializes her mother's condition, enacting a familial legacy of exposure, fragility, and social marginalization.

He Chengyao's work interrogates the process by which maternal trauma becomes filial inheritance. Both *Opening the Great Wall* (2001) and *Mama and Me* (2001)[25] examine how the Cultural Revolution and associated cultural pressures inscribed pathological fear in her mother, a legacy subsequently imposed on Chengyao during her childhood and into adulthood.[26] These performances refuse therapeutic resolution. They instead enact a persistent negotiation with wounds that resist closure.

Crucially, Chengyao deliberately rejects the body as a symbolic substitute for trauma. The body becomes instead the medium through which inherited suffering is activated. Performances of temporal and relational immediacy distinguish Chengyao's practice from representational strategies that rely on distance or retrospection; familial trauma is depicted as a re-lived condition persisting with the present body, entirely separate from viewing it as a historical event. Inheritance remains central to the artistic form and Chengyao's framework. Chengyao's performances foreground the expectation that daughters bear emotional

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[22] Qinlin Wei, "Motherhood as Method: Chinese Feminism and Gendered Resistance in the Works of Yu Hong and He Chengyao," *Art and Society* 4, no. 4 (May 2025): 34–44, https://doi.org/10.63593/AS.2709-9830.2025.05.005.Wei, 2025

[23] Figure 3. He Chengyao. *Opening the Great Wall* (2001). Performance art, photographic documentation.

[24] Sasha Welland, 'Six Opening the Great Wall', in *Experimental Beijing* (New York, USA: Duke University Press, 2020). pp. 206–235.

[25] Figure 8. He Chengyao. *Mama and Me (*2001). Performance art, photographic documentation.

[26] Felicity Ostergaard, "He Chengyao and Chen Qingqing: Art Practice as a Method of Healing," *Guan Kan: Thinking with Contemporary Chinese Art*, March 3, 2025, https://www.guankanjournal.art/journalessays/he-chengyao-and-chen-qingqing-art-practice-as-a-method-of-healing

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responsibility for familial care, particularly in relation to mental illness. Her body becomes a conduit through which private suffering is made public, exposing how women absorb and perform the emotional labor of family trauma.[27] Such patterning echoes Lauren Berlant's "cruel optimism," wherein attachments to ideals of care, stability, and filial duty become sources of harm. Chengyao's performances expose the cost of sustaining fantasies of the 'good life' constructed atop unacknowledged suffering.[28] Her performances in public spaces, such as *Opening the Great Wall* (2001), generated intense reactions from onlookers, underscoring the powerful impact of her art in transforming private suffering into public witness.

In *Mama and Me* (2001), Chengyao stands behind her seated mother, who is holding a rotten apple. The photographic series captures moments of their interaction, with the mother's gaze occasionally shifting. The compositional hierarchy centers the mother, while Chengyao's head is nearly excluded from the frame, visually encoding relational disconnection. This photographic series represents one of their first collaborative works of the mother and daughter together, signaling an acceptance of estrangement within the maternal bond. Chengyao's decision to perform nude alongside her mother operates as an embodied epistemology, with nakedness serving as a method for approximating maternal experience. The mutual vulnerability enacts recognition rather than reconciliation, foregrounding the impossibility of separating personal trauma from familial inheritance.

Chengyao's work extends beyond endurance, functioning as a method of healing from her complex relationship with her mother and the broader socio-political impact of the Cultural Revolution.[29] Performance operates as an ethical confrontation, compelling viewers to engage

[27] Lauren Berlant. *Cruel Optimism* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2011), 1; Ostergaard 2025, , "He Chengyao and Chen Qingqing."
[28] Lauren Berlant. *Cruel Optimism* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2011), 1.
[29] Ostergaard (2025), "He Chengyao and Chen Qingqing."

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with vulnerability without representational mediation. This approach insists that trauma is directly lived and shared in temporally unfolding space. Live, corporeal confrontation distinguishes Chengyao's method from her contemporaries by transforming the endurance of trauma into mutual, real-time experience rather than mediated reflection.[30]

Existing scholarship on contemporary Chinese performance art often situates Chengyao's work within the context of bodily experimentation and the avant-garde,[31] emphasizing transgression, corporeality, and resistance to normative aesthetics. However, such approaches can overlook that Chengyao's practice foregrounds familial intimacy, inherited obligation, and intergenerational trauma. A more nuanced analysis reveals how Chengyao interrogates the intersections of domestic caregiving and public exposure, and how the maternal body functions as a site of vulnerability alongside cultural and affective negotiation. Her performances simultaneously subvert aesthetic norms and critically engage with the relational and ethical dimensions of intergenerational care, complicating conventional assumptions about filial duty and female resilience.[32] The body functions ancestrally as an archive and witness, holding histories that resist articulation.

By accentuating performance as a medium for inheritance, He Chengyao's work advances the exploration of hereditary trauma across artistic forms while contributing to contemporary discourse on embodiment, gender, and intergenerational history. Her practice

[30] He Chengyao, "Lift the Cover from Your Head," in *Yishu: Journal of Contemporary Chinese Art*, vol. 2, no. 3, Fall 2003; Eva Kit Wah Man, *Bodies in China: Philosophy, Aesthetics, Gender, and Politics* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2017), 84.

[31] Liu Yiching (2010) Maoist discourse and the mobilization of emotions in revolutionary China. Mod China 36(3):329–362; Wu Hung. *Contemporary Chinese Art: A History, 1970s–2000s*. London: Thames & Hudson, 2014.

[32] Wu Hung. *Contemporary Chinese Art: A History, 1970s–2000s*. London: Thames & Hudson, 2014; Wei, Qinlin. "Motherhood as Method: Chinese Feminism and Gendered Resistance in the Works of Yu Hong and He Chengyao." *Art and Society* 4, no. 4 (May 2025): 34–44. https://doi.org/10.63593/AS.2709-9830.2025.05.005.

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demonstrates that trauma transmits through embodied vulnerability formed by gendered expectations of care, extending beyond images or narratives alone. In contrast to painting's visual mediation and writing's reflective negotiation, performance exposes the immediacy and persistence of familial trauma, suggesting that certain histories are most powerfully engaged through shared discomfort, affective risk, and corporeal presence. Chengyao's work beckons scholars to reconsider how gender, embodiment, and performance intersect to produce new understandings of inherited suffering within both Chinese contemporary art and global contexts.

Fundamental to this exploration is the guiding principle of relational ethics, which emphasizes reciprocal and empathetic interactions that recognize familial trauma across time. This study draws on an ethical framework that stresses intergenerational responsibility and the development of empathetic connections through art. Relational ethics involves understanding the responsibilities and connections between individuals as shaped by inherited experiences and historical contexts. Another key concept is postmemory, which refers to the transmission of traumatic experiences across generations, affecting the descendants' understanding of their identities and histories. By engaging various artistic practices, contemporary Chinese artists illuminate the ethical responsibilities associated with inherited memories, pointing to the transformative potential of postmemory. This ethical lens guides the reader through diverse case studies, giving insights into how art, beyond depicting narratives, facilitates a richer engagement with collective and personal histories. The analyses that follow demonstrate how these artistic expressions both reflect and impel ethical engagement with the past, ultimately supporting the concluding claims about art's role in shaping cultural memory.

Contemporary Chinese artists conceptualize familial trauma as a phenomenon transmitted and shaped through diverse artistic media, efficiently transforming their work into a 'postmemory

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laboratory.' This framework foregrounds the priority of addressing inherited trauma, highlighting why these artistic acts matter across generations. Rather than focusing on a single historical theme, these artists adopt a broader perspective. By treating the medium as an active agent, they demonstrate that painting, moving image, and performance, coupled with the transmission of family history, shape the experience and management of trauma over time. The texture and layering of paint in visual art evoke the complexity of emotional wounds, while the physical fortitude required for performance art underscores the persistence of trauma. Similarly, the reflective process of writing allows for an exploration of memory and identity that is equally intimate and detached. The selection of Zhang Xiaogang, Song Dong, and He Chengyao as case studies was intentional, as their work exemplifies how different mediums engage with the complex narratives of familial inheritance. Each artist was selected for their distinctive approach and for the way their chosen medium enhances our understanding of historical pain. Xiaogang's paintings, Dong's archival installations, and Chengyao's performance art each provide a distinctive lens in examining the manifestations of inherited trauma. Their practices illustrate how the noteworthy qualities of each medium enhance our understanding of historical pain through visual, textual, and performative methods. Inheritance thus functions as a process that manifests differently across artistic forms, indicating how art is a force that addresses and transforms historical pain, linking the divide between past and present through the lens of postmemory.[33]

Memory work is seen in Zhang Xiaogang's *Bloodline: Big Family* series (1993 - 1999)[34], in which familial memory is visually organized through photographic inheritance and emotional

[33] Marianne Hirsch. "Family Pictures: Maus, Mourning, and Post-Memory." (*Discourse* 15, no. 2, 1992–93): 3–29.
[34] Figure 1. Zhang Xiaogang. *Bloodline: Big Family* series (1993 –1999). Oil on canvas. Various dimensions.

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restraint. It also reveals the limits of pictorial representation, particularly its reliance on distance and repetition. Song Dong's *Touching My Father* (1997 - 2011)[35] combines artistic practice and filial encounter, using writing and tactile engagement, negotiating intimacy, loss, and ethical responsibility toward the parent.[36] He Chengyao's performance practice stages inherited trauma directly on the female body, exposing the gendered dimensions of vulnerability and care within post-socialist China.[37]

Collectively, these works reveal that understanding familial trauma in contemporary Chinese art requires attention to the distinct affordances of each artistic medium rather than reliance on a singular theoretical or aesthetic approach. Examining these practices together demonstrates how varied mediums produce a more nuanced account of inherited trauma. Xiaogang's photographs, with their muted palettes and repetitive imagery, emphasize emotional distance and anonymity, while Chengyao's performance art draws attention to the physical and immediate realities of trauma inheritance. By bringing Xiaogang's and Chengyao's approaches into dialogue, the discussion illustrates how different frameworks can simultaneously challenge and enrich our understanding of historical inheritance and emotional labor. This synthesis underscores the necessity of analyzing inheritance as a process shaped by the unique qualities of specific mediums, including their capacities for distance, negotiation, and embodiment. By comparing these international practices with the approaches of Chinese artists, art across various global contexts clearly provides new possibilities for the transmission and ethical engagement of cultural memory. However, it is important to acknowledge the scope and limitations of this study. The focus is predominantly on contemporary Chinese artists, emphasizing urban contexts and

[35] Figure 2. Song Dong. *Touching My Father* (1997–2011). Video installation.
[36] Welland, Sasha. S.-L. (2020) 'Six Opening the Great Wall', in *Experimental Beijing*. (New York, USA: Duke University Press). pp. 206–235.
[37] Figure 3. He Chengyao. *Opening the Great Wall* (2001). Performance art, photographic documentation.

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generational trauma, which might not fully capture rural or class-based experiences of inheritance and memory. Nonetheless, these explorations offer a crucial framework for understanding the broader dynamics of intergenerational trauma. Ultimately, this synthesis reinforces the central argument that artistic explorations of familial trauma provide frameworks for both personal and collective responsibility, inviting deeper, more empathetic engagement with inherited histories. Furthermore, these insights contribute to global discourses on post-dictatorship art practices by highlighting how artists worldwide can transform trauma into a shared language of resistance and memory. By juxtaposing these findings with international art movements, we see the potential for a broader dialogue on how art functions as a tool for reconciliation and healing, extending the relevance and impact of these practices beyond China.

The afterlife of Maoism, as these artists reveal, is not confined to museums or monuments. It lives in the hesitation before touching a parent, in the compulsive hoarding of objects, and in the daughter's body bearing witness to the mother's breakdown. By insisting on medium-specificity, on painting's distance, writing's negotiation, performance's immediacy, these artists demonstrate that there is no single way to inherit trauma, and thus no single way to survive it. Their work refuses the consolations of resolution, offering instead a more difficult gift, the recognition that familial inheritance is an ongoing labor, ethical and affective, that each generation must undertake anew. In doing so, they transform contemporary Chinese art into a crucial site for rethinking how political violence becomes personal history and how art might hold space for what cannot be resolved.

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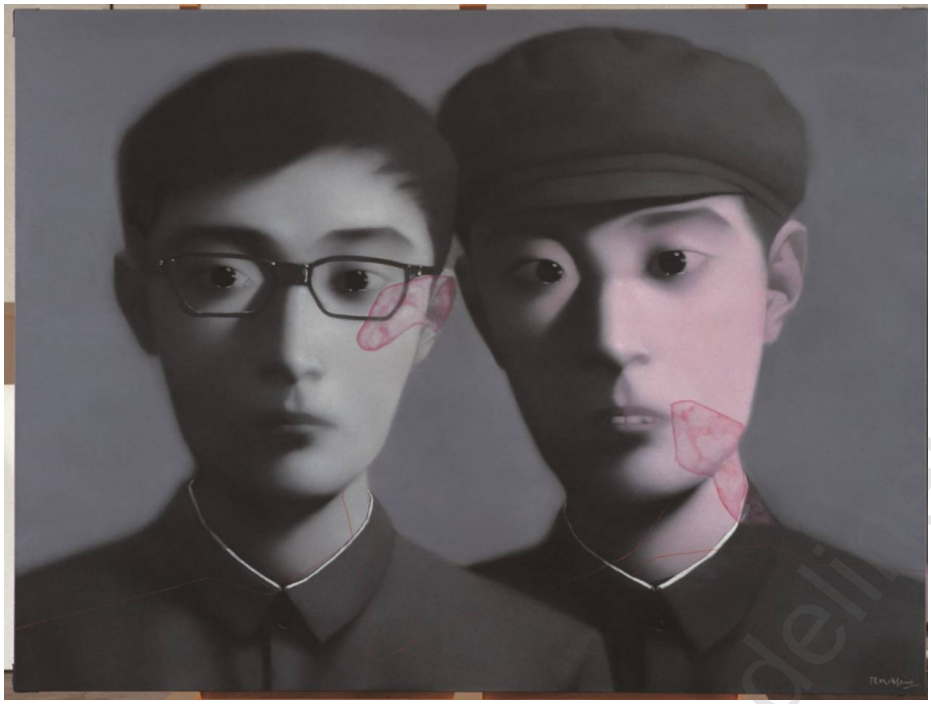


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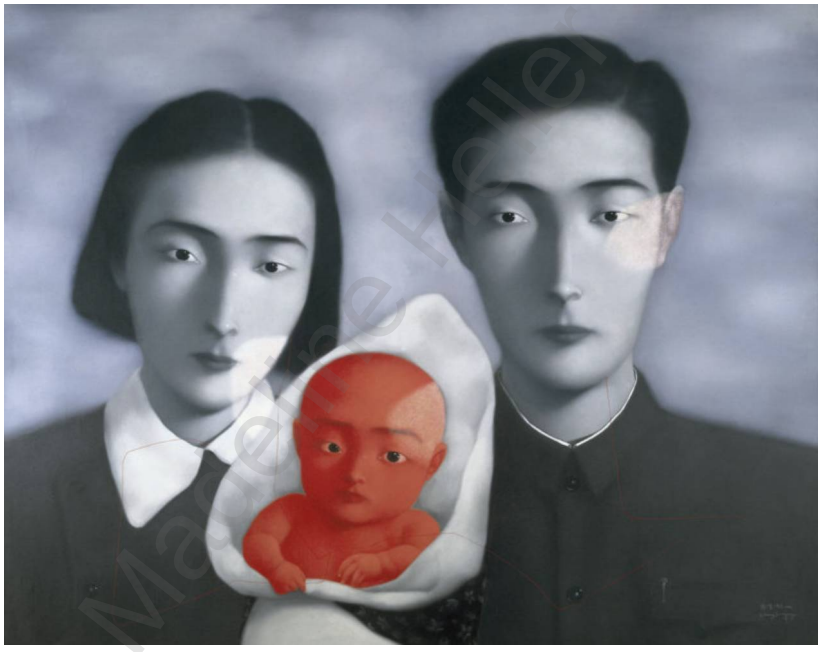


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Figure 2.



Figure 2. Song Dong. *Touching My Father*. 1997–2011. Part I Video installation. (Three Parts)

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Figure 2. Song Dong. *Touching My Father*. 1997–2011. Part II. Video installation. (Three Parts)

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Figure 2. Song Dong. *Touching My Father*. 1997–2011. Part III. Video installation. (Three Parts)

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Figure 3.



He Chengyao, *Opening the Great Wall*, 2001, performance, Courtesy of the artist. Source: awarewomenartist.com.

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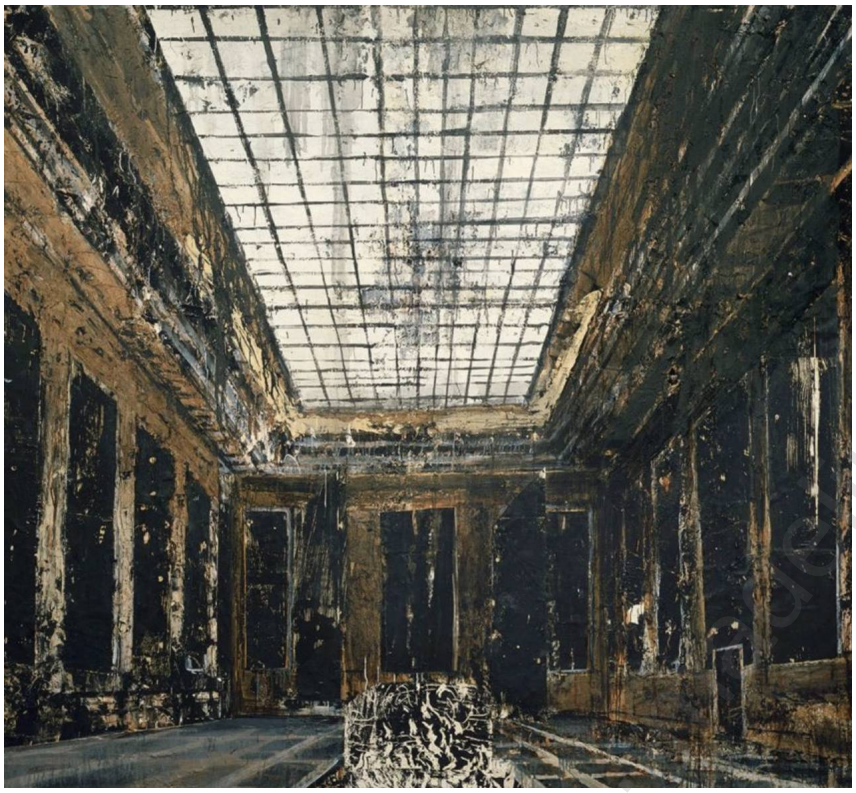


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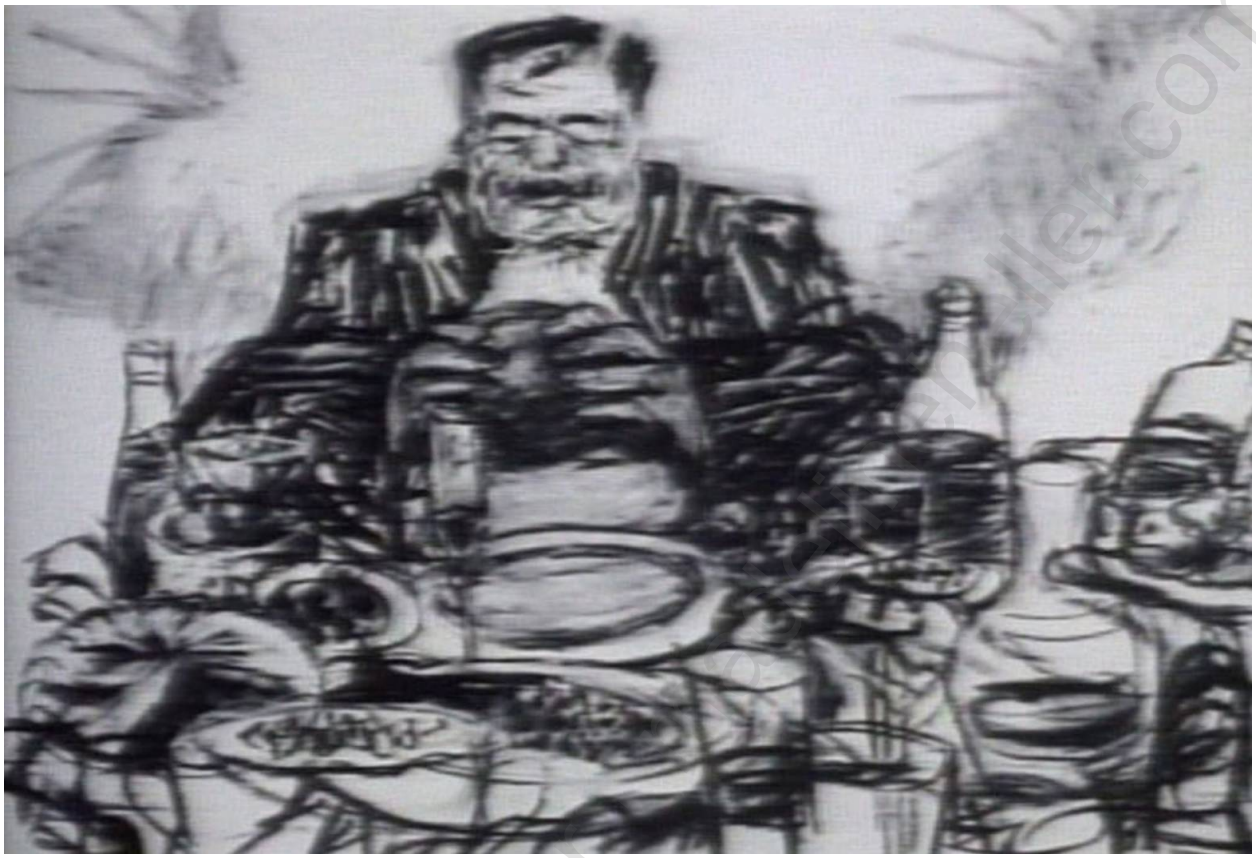


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Figure 7.



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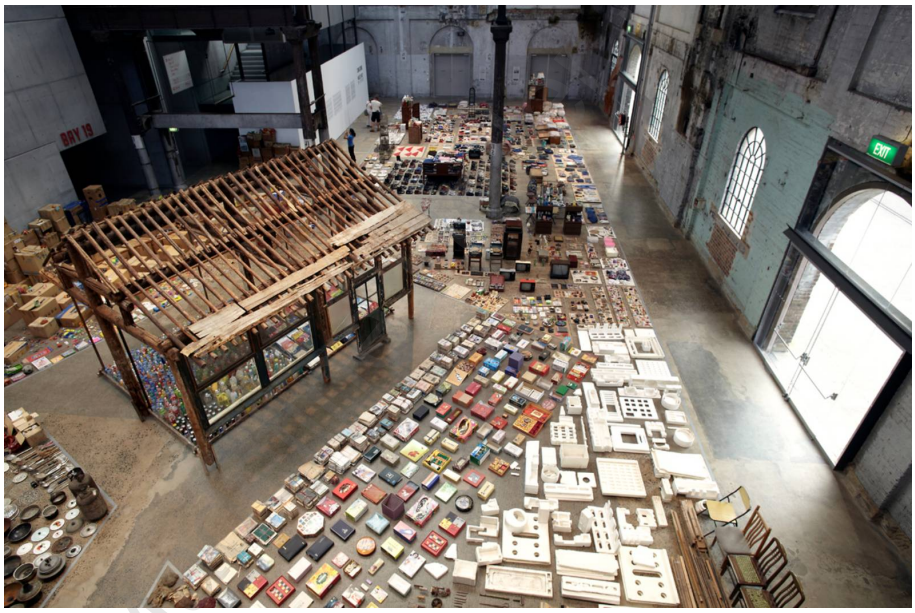


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